



NO. 03 · AUTUMN 2025

VOID DISPATCH

Void Dispatch is a zine about cities, infrastructure, and the systems we live inside. Free to read. Free to print. Free to leave somewhere.

Contributing writers: Dana Ferris, M. Okafor, T. Nakamura, S. Reyes, P. Voss.

Printed on whatever you have.

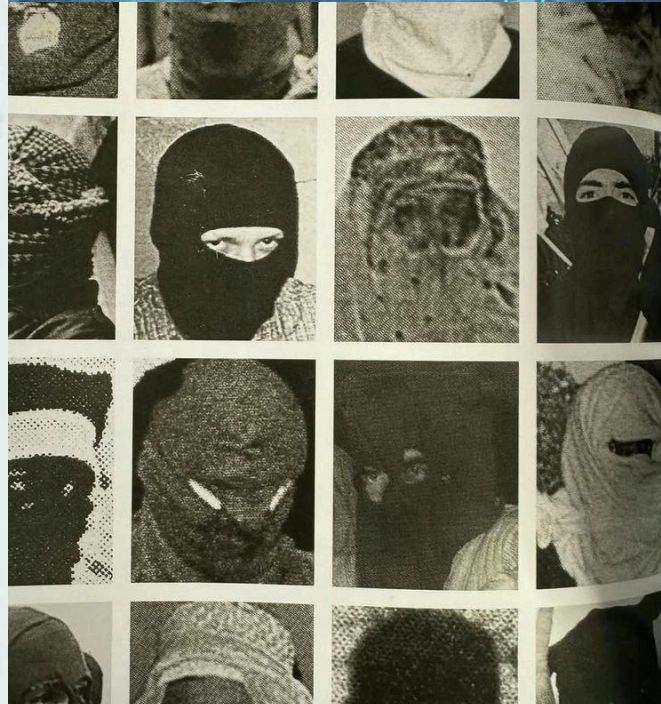
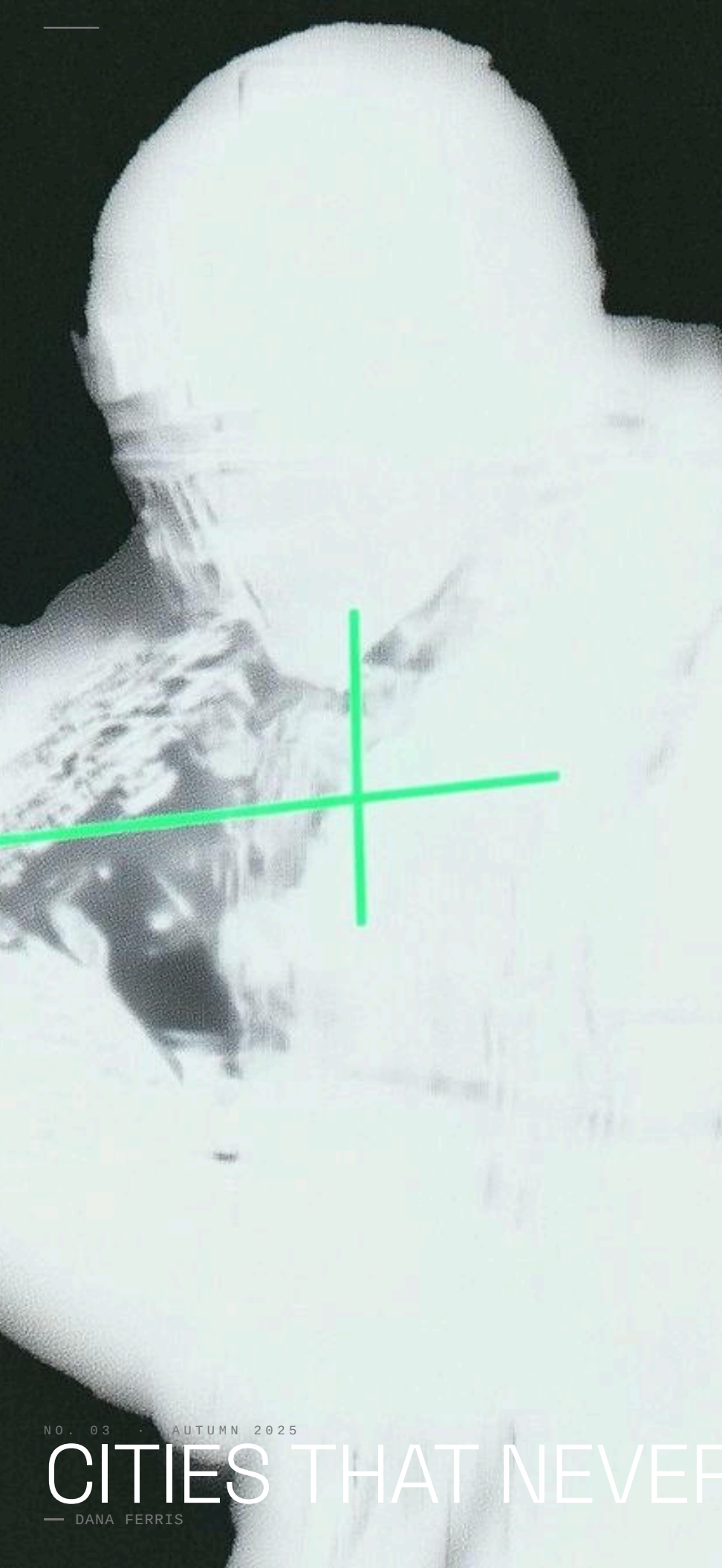
void-dispatch @ proton.me



NO. 03 · AUTUMN 2025

VOID DISPATCH

1	_____	CITIES THAT NEVER SLEEP
2	_____	THREE WAYS TO DISAPPEAR
3	_____	THE LAST PAYPHONE
4	_____	SMALL GRID THEORY
5	_____	THE MAINTENANCE WORKERS
6	_____	THE SIGNAL LAYER



NO. 03 · AUTUMN 2025

CITIES THAT NEVER SLEEP

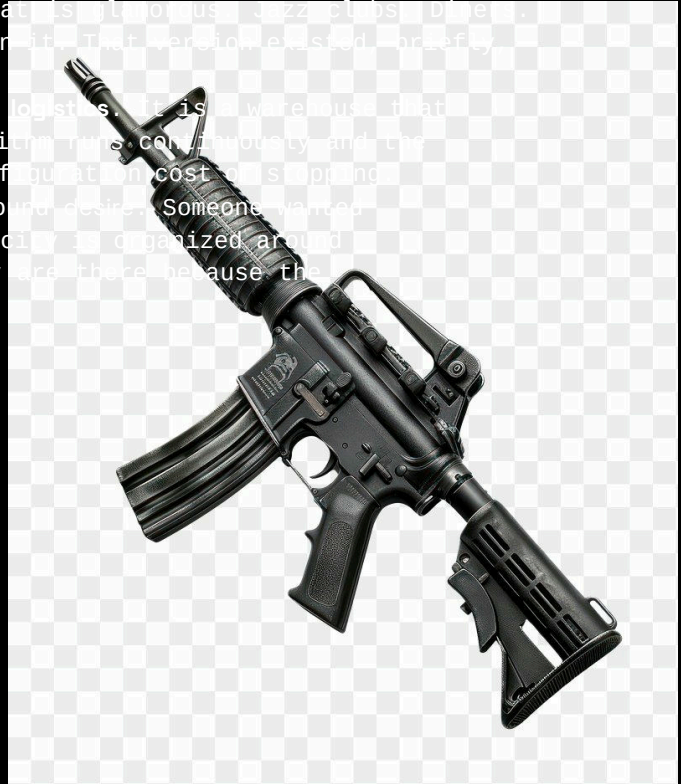
— DANA FERRIS

-- ARTICLE

CITIES THAT NEVER SLEEP

— DANA FERRIS

There is a version of the 24-hour city that is still out there. It was the last bus home and someone interesting on it. That version lasted briefly in a handful of places, and it was good. The version we have now is different. It is logistical. It is a warehouse that cannot go dark because the sortation algorithm runs continuously and the humans inside it are cheaper than the reconfiguration cost of stopping. The romantic 24-hour city was organized around desire. Someone wanted to be there at 3am. The logistical 24-hour city is organized around throughput. No one wants to be there. They are there because the model requires it.



"/ "FULFILLMENT CENTER, OUTER RING ROAD

QUOTE

The lights are always on here. That used to mean something.

— OUTSIDE A FULFILLMENT CENTER, 3:14AM



It's the city in the night that planners, when they invoke "vibrancy," consistently fail to see. Vibrancy is not a property of illuminated windows. It is a property of people choosing to be somewhere. We built infrastructure for the night and called it nightlife. We built coverage for every hour and called it community. We built safety in every corner and called it safety. None of these things are neutral.

A city that cannot sleep is not
awake. It is running a process.



NOVEMBER 2025

THREE WAYS TO DISAPPEAR

THREE WAYS TO DISAPPEAR

— M. OKAFOR



"/ "ANALOG, UNCONNECTED

Method two: reduce identity surface area. You have more accounts than you need. Some are tied to your real name, phone number, a payment method, a fingerprint. The reduction is not deactivation. It is stop creating new ones. Every new account is a new exposure surface.

make boring choices visible. Notice when you are making choices. Not every choice requires a different decision. But defaults were set by someone whose interests are not yours. Default on: location sharing, analytics, cross-site tracking. Reversing these – not in every case, just deliberately – change what flows through the pipes.

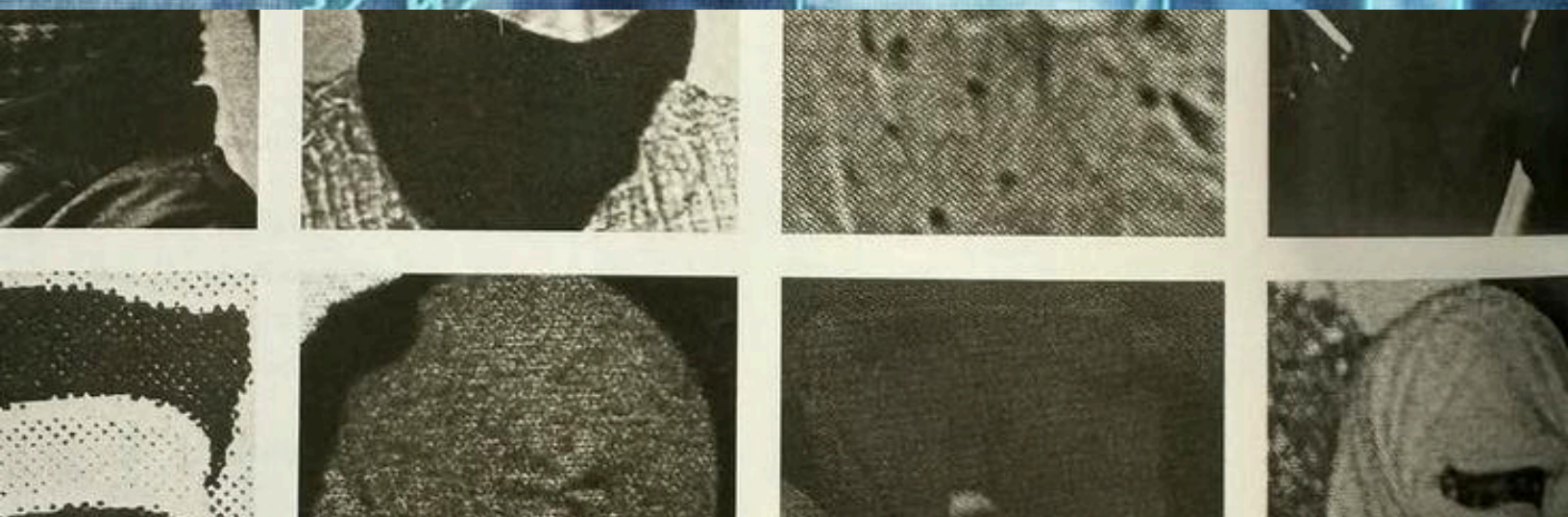
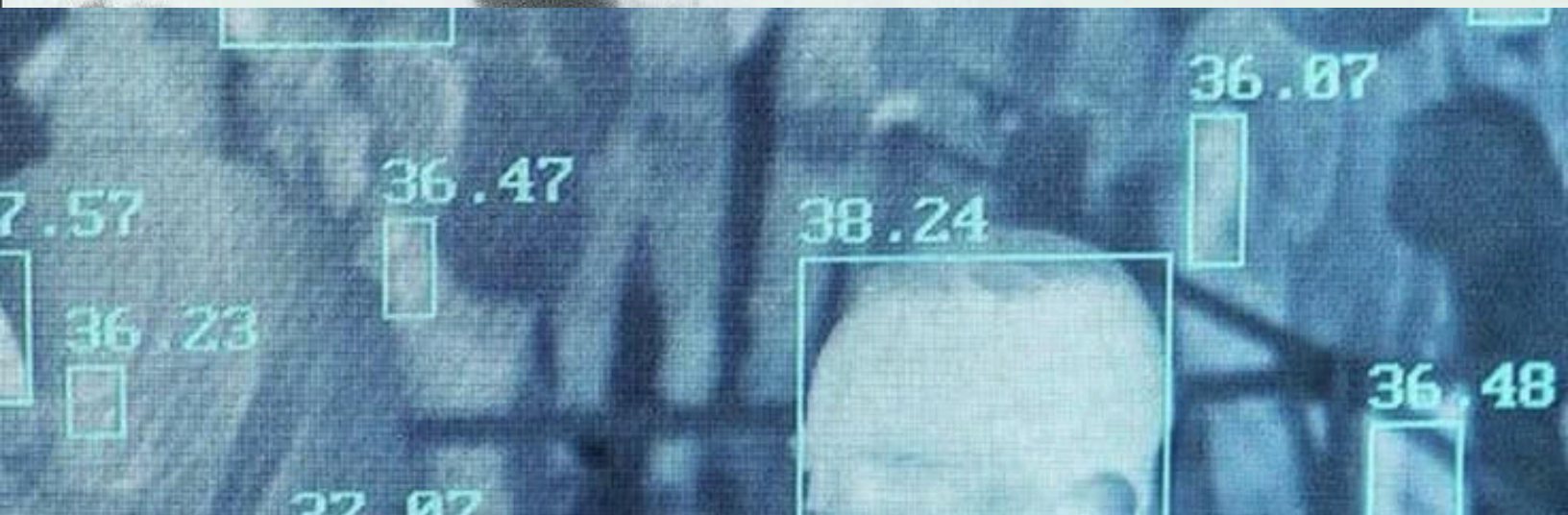
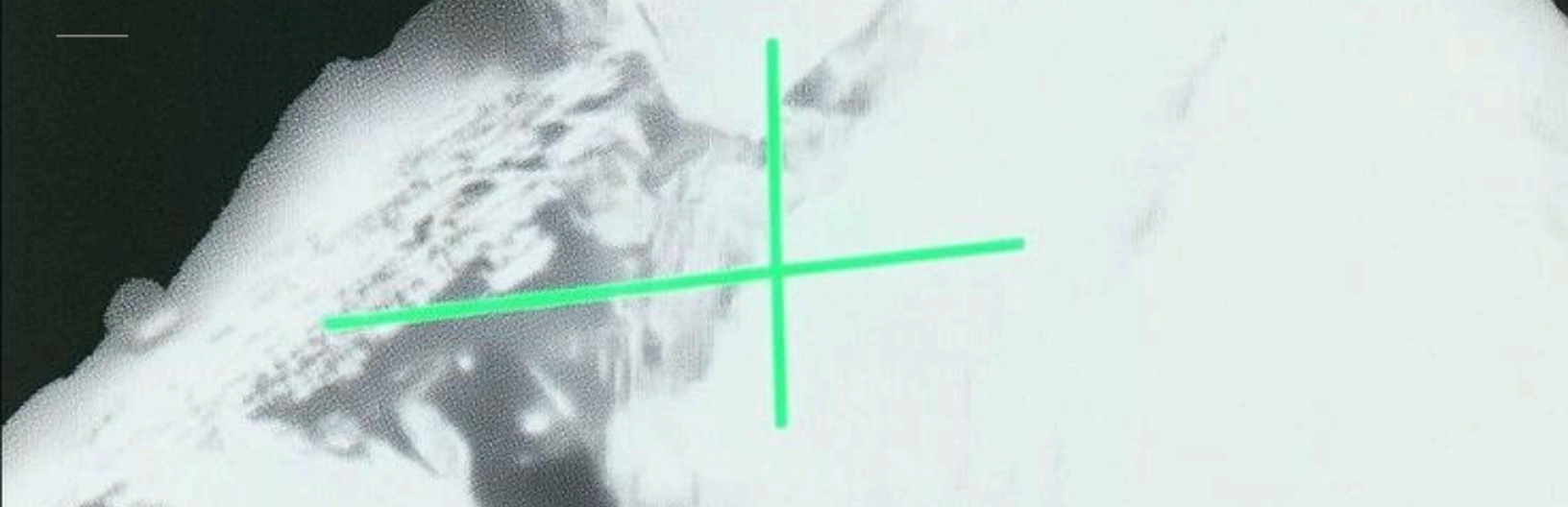
piece. This is a practice piece. Paranoia is a specific adversary. Practice assumes a general adversary responds proportionally.

Method one: go analog for the boring stuff. Most boring stuff is passive and opportunistic. It collects whatever flows through the pipes. A notebook does not have a privacy policy. A pocket calendar does not sync to a data broker. Shopping lists, personal notes, appointments with people you trust – none of these need a network.



THE ACTUAL THREAT MODEL

You are probably not being targeted specifically. You are in a database being queried by systems with no opinion about you as a person. The goal is not to escape the database. The goal is to make the query less useful.



THE LAST PAYPHONE

MAY 2005 / AUTUMN 2005

— T. NAKAMURA

-- ARTICLE

THE LAST PAYPHONE

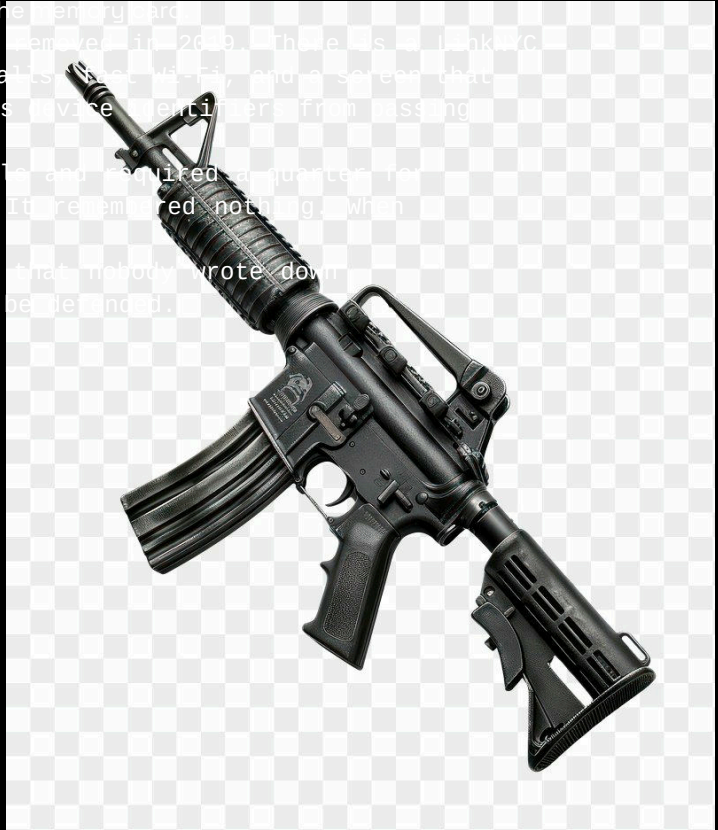
— T. NAKAMURA

A photo essay without photos, because we lost the emergency card.

The payphone on Delancey and Essex was removed in 2009. There is a kiosk there now. The kiosk offers free calls, has a USB port, and a screen that displays advertisements. It also collects voice identifiers from passing phones.

The payphone offered free emergency calls and required a quarter for everything else. It collected nothing. It remembered nothing. When you hung up, the conversation was over.

This was not a bug. This was a feature that nobody wrote down, because nobody thought it would need to be defended.

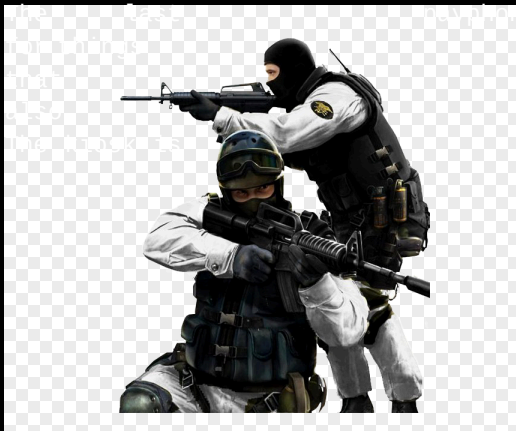


"/ "DELANCEY AND ESSEX, 2019

QUOTE

You could call anyone and they couldn't call you back unless they already knew where you were.

— A PERSON WHO REMEMBERED THE QUARTER



The payphone in New York City was removed from a hotel lobby in 2022. It is now in a museum. Which is the correct place society has decided it no longer needs, and which is the correct place to go to feel the specific grief of infrastructure loss.

faster. The kiosk is free. The kiosk is always available. The kiosk knows your phone was near it at 11:47am on a Tuesday in March.



NO. 03 · AUTUMN 2025

SMALL GRID THEORY

— S. REYES

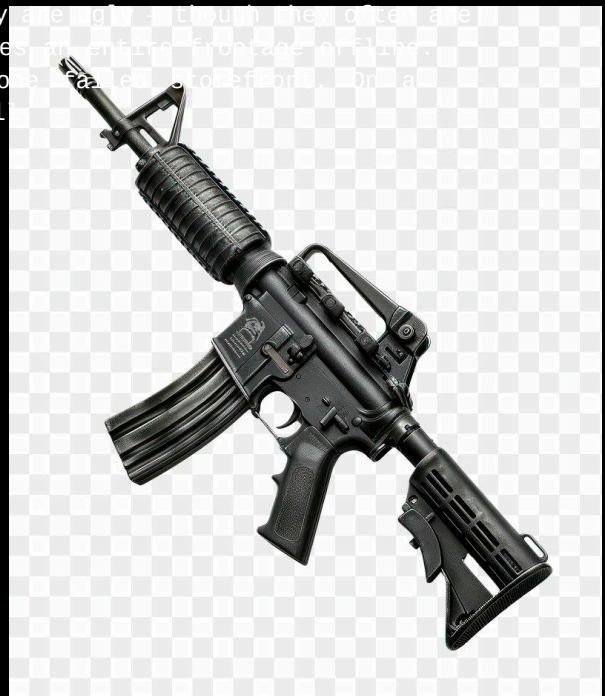
SMALL GRID THEORY

— S. REYES



Large blocks produce dead zones. Not because they are big, although they often are — but because a single failed anchor tenant takes up the entire frontage on the block. On a small block, one failed storefront is one failed storefront only. On a superblock, it is four hundred feet of blank wall.

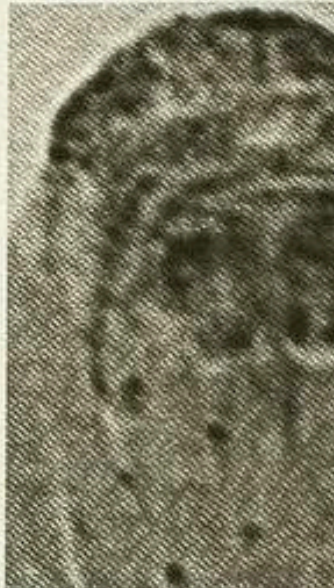
Small blocks share one physical characteristic that urban planners consistently undervalue: **small blocks**. Not “walkable” in the sense of having sidewalks. Not “mixed-use” in the sense of having a Starbucks on the ground floor and a condo tower. Small blocks. Short distances between intersections. Many choices per square mile. The reason small blocks win is not aesthetic. It is practical. A grid of small blocks offers exponentially more route choices than a grid of large blocks covering the same area. More route choices means more foot traffic. More foot traffic means more storefronts viable means more



Density is not the variable.
Granularity is the variable.



t walkability onto a large-block grid by adding mixed-use zoning. You can add a coffee shop on the floor of a 700-foot-frontage building and it will be a coffee shop in an airport. Because it is. We have to be small first. Everything else follows from the blocks. Jane Jacobs said this in 1961. We have spent sixty years building the opposite.



TENANCE WORKERS

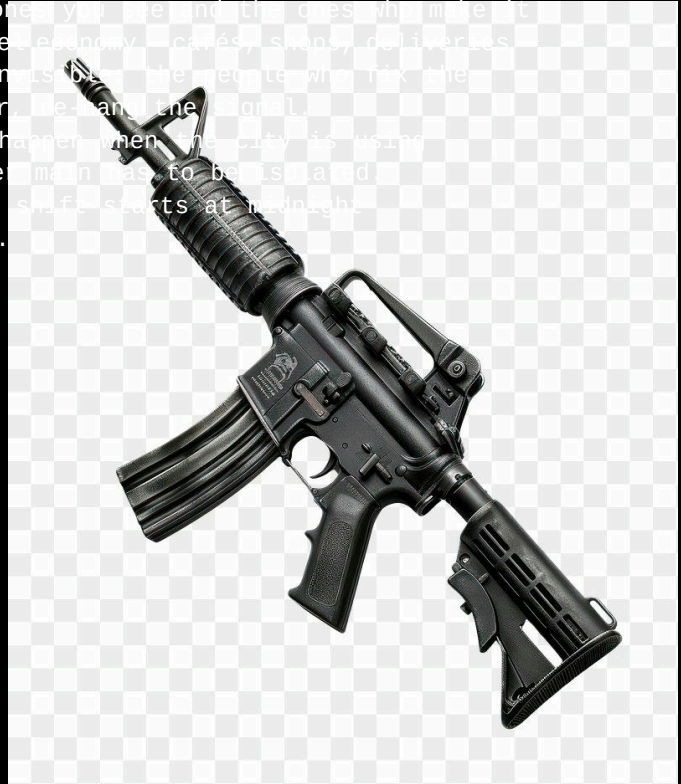
NO. 03 • AUTUMN 2025

— 038

THE MAINTENANCE WORKERS

— P. VOSS

Every city has two kinds of workers. The one you see and the one who make it possible for you to see them. The street-level worker — the janitor, the delivery person, the maintenance worker — depends on a substrate that is mostly invisible. The worker who maintains the pipes, patch the road, swap the transformer, and the signal. They work at 2am because the work cannot happen when the city is used by itself. The road has to be empty. The water main has to be isolated. The substation has to be de-energized. The shift starts at midnight and ends before anyone notices it happened.



"/ "SUBSTATION CREW, 2:30AM

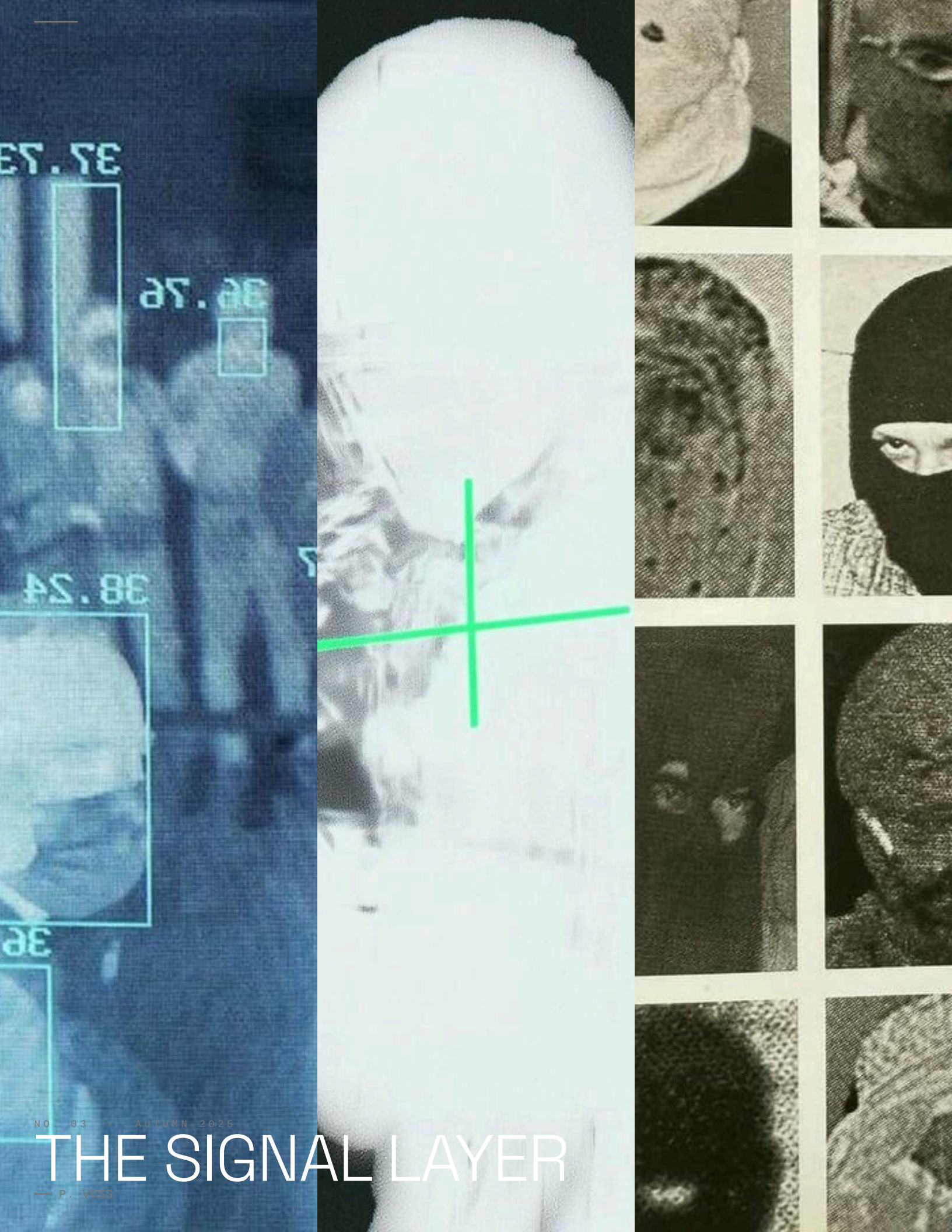


INVISIBILITY AS SUCCESS METRIC

The KPI for infrastructure maintenance is the absence of events. Nothing happened. That is the goal. That is how you know it worked.

We have built an economy around visibility. Likes, impressions. And then we have built a world on top of people whose best outcome is that you never think about them at all.





NO 03 · AUTUMN 2025

THE SIGNAL LAYER

— P. VOSS

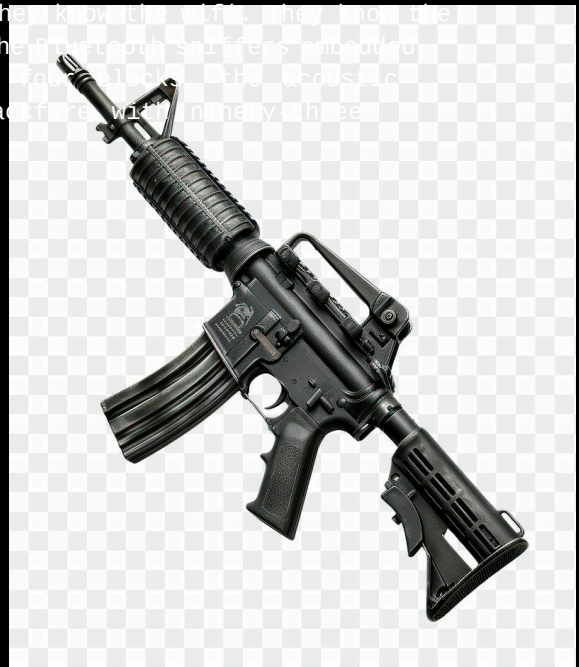
THE SIGNAL LAYER

— P. VOSS



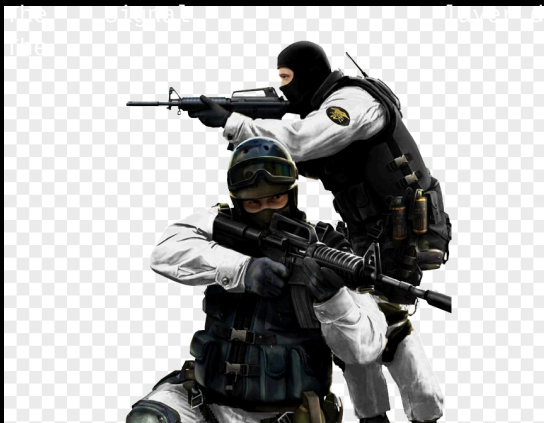
Every city runs on a layer of things you can't see. Not the pipes, not the wires – those are findable, mappable, and can be pre-flagged before you dig. The signal layer is different. It is the mesh of transmissions that tells traffic light what the car did three blocks away, tells the transit authority the bus is running four minutes late, that tells the logistics platform the driver has paused. The signal layer is where the city becomes legible to itself. Without it, the buses are just buses. With it, the buses are a dataset. The streets are a dataset. The city reads itself continuously and the data it collects changes what it does.

Most people do not know the signal layer exists. They know the light that tells the cell signal. They do not know the mesh, the LIDAR, the data that's stored in lamp posts, the license plate readers every road has, the acoustic monitors that can tell a gunshot from a car backfire with ninety-three percent accuracy.

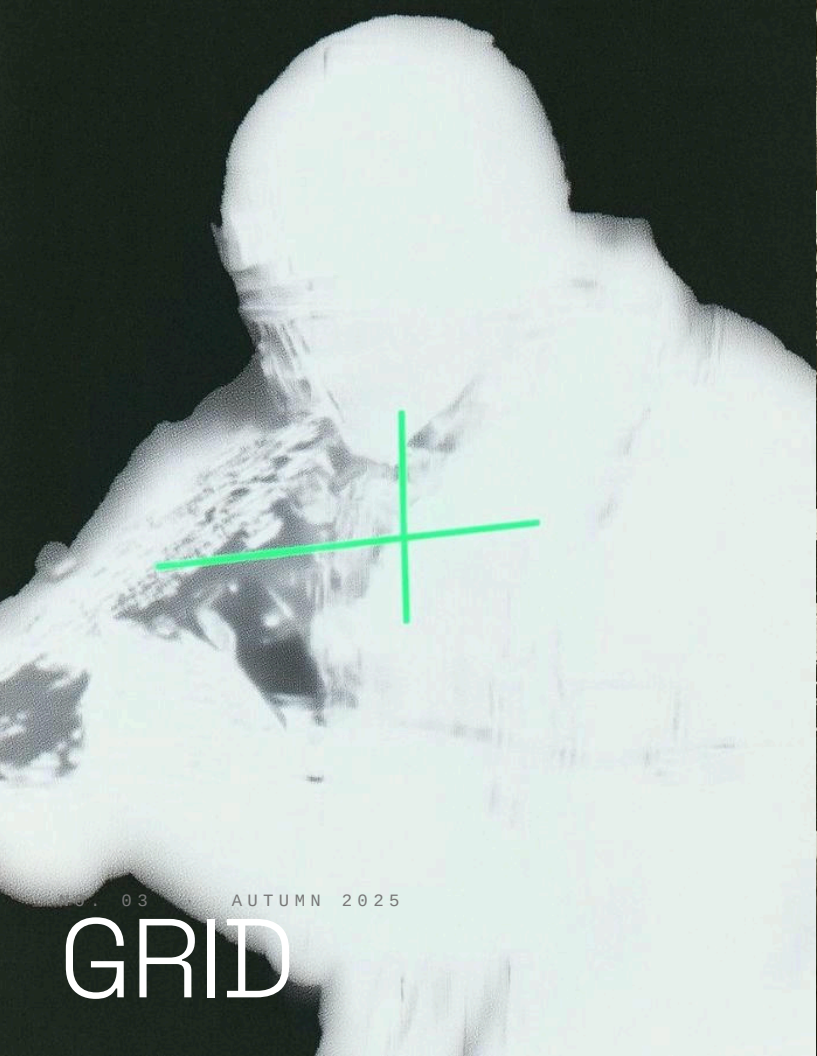


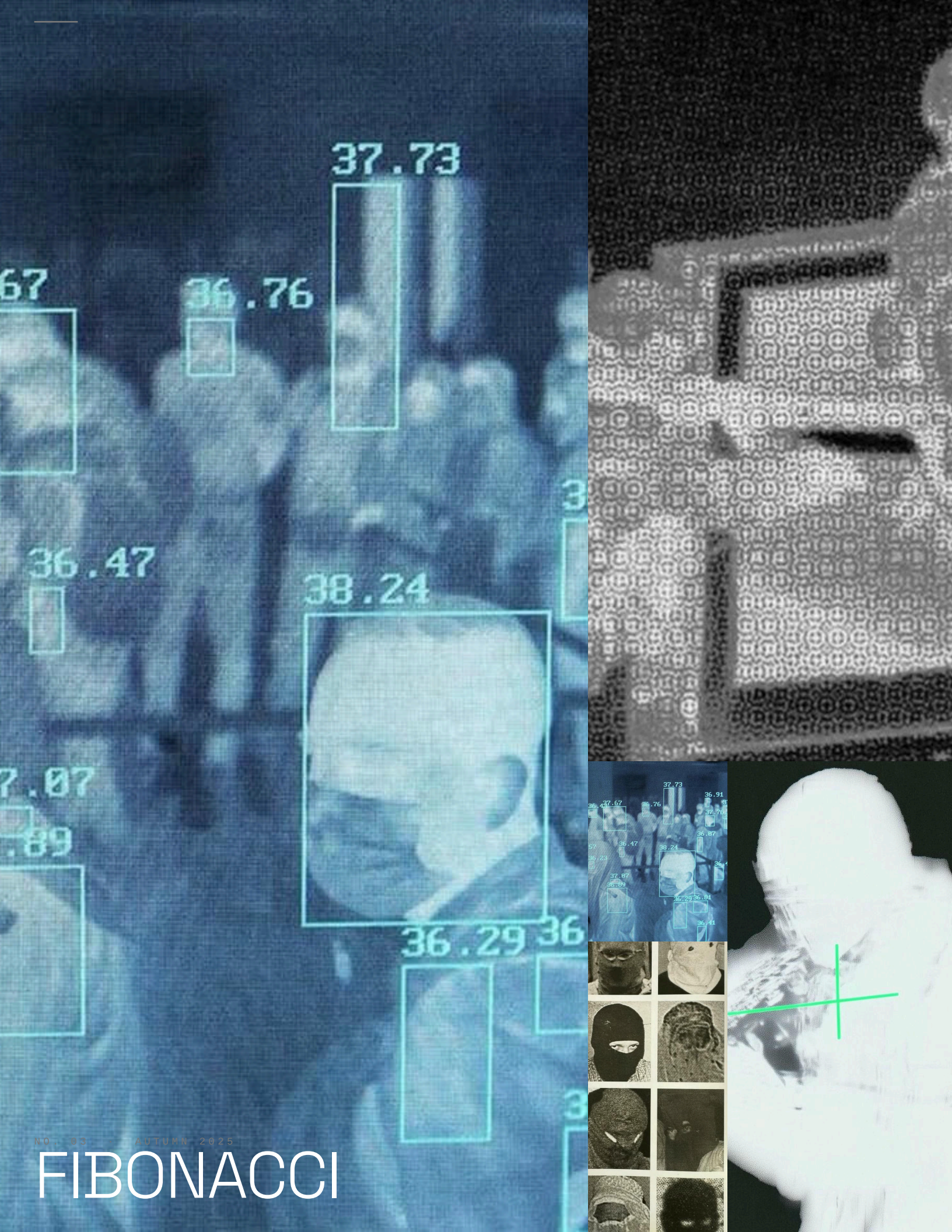
WHAT THE SIGNAL LAYER KNOWS

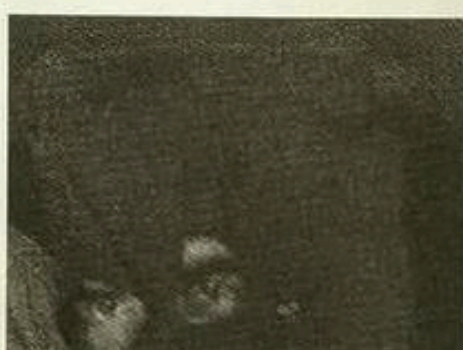
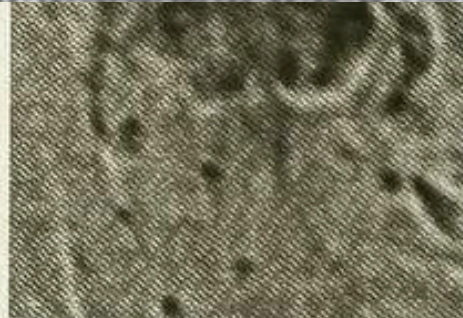
Where you were. How fast you moved. What device you carried. Whether you stopped. For how long. Whether you stopped at that spot before.



The signal layer does not forget. The buses forget. The people forget. The signal layer keeps a log.

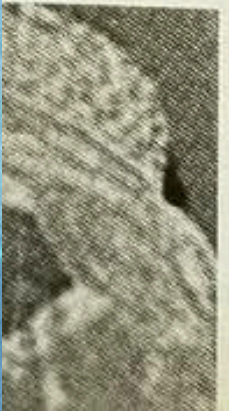
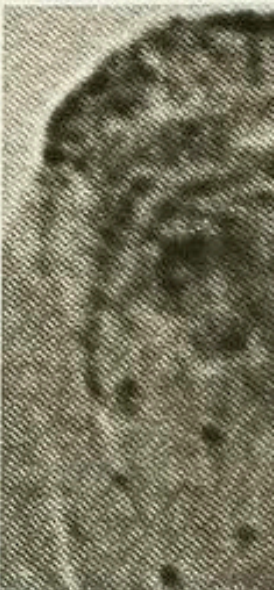
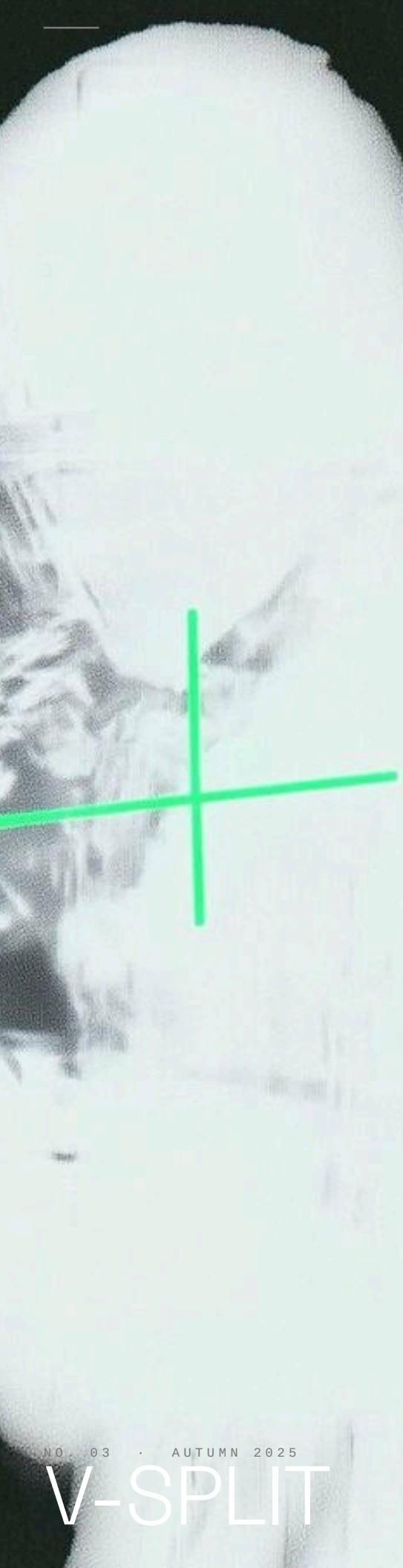


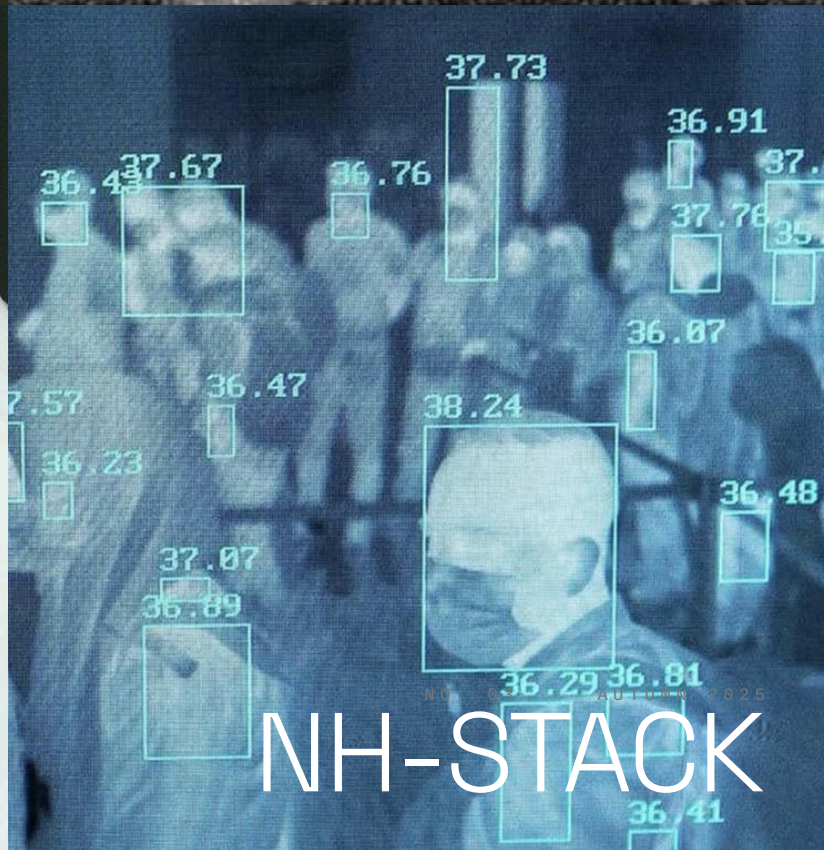
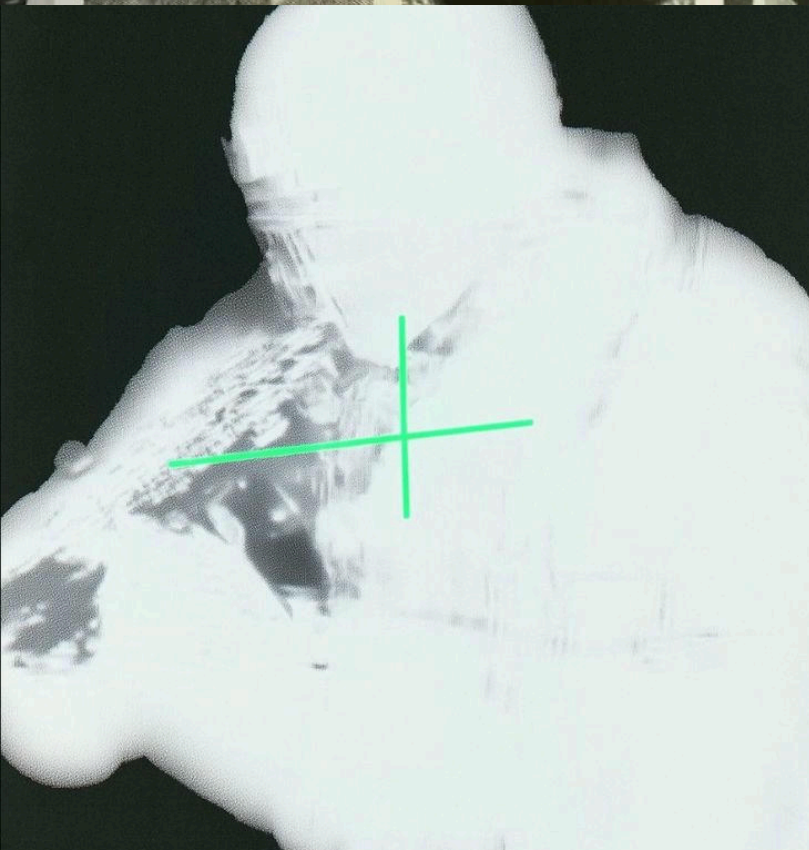
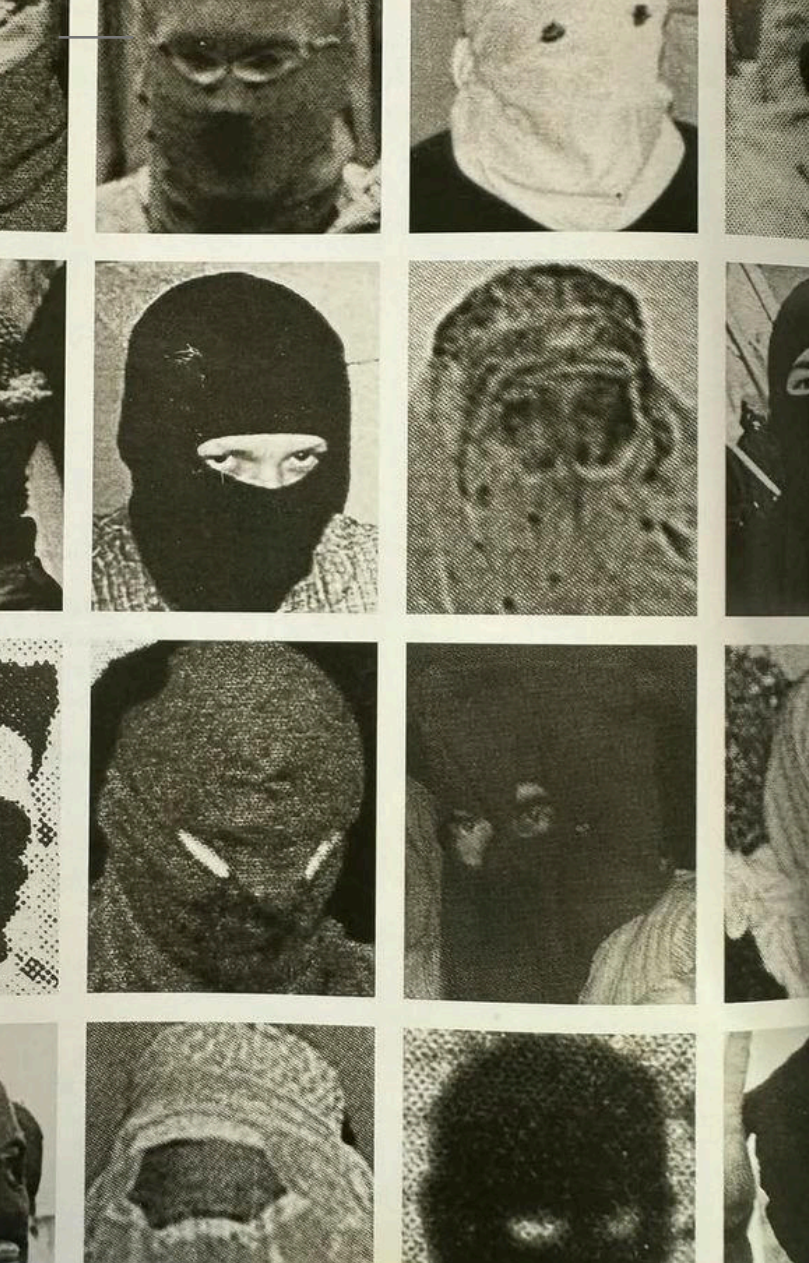


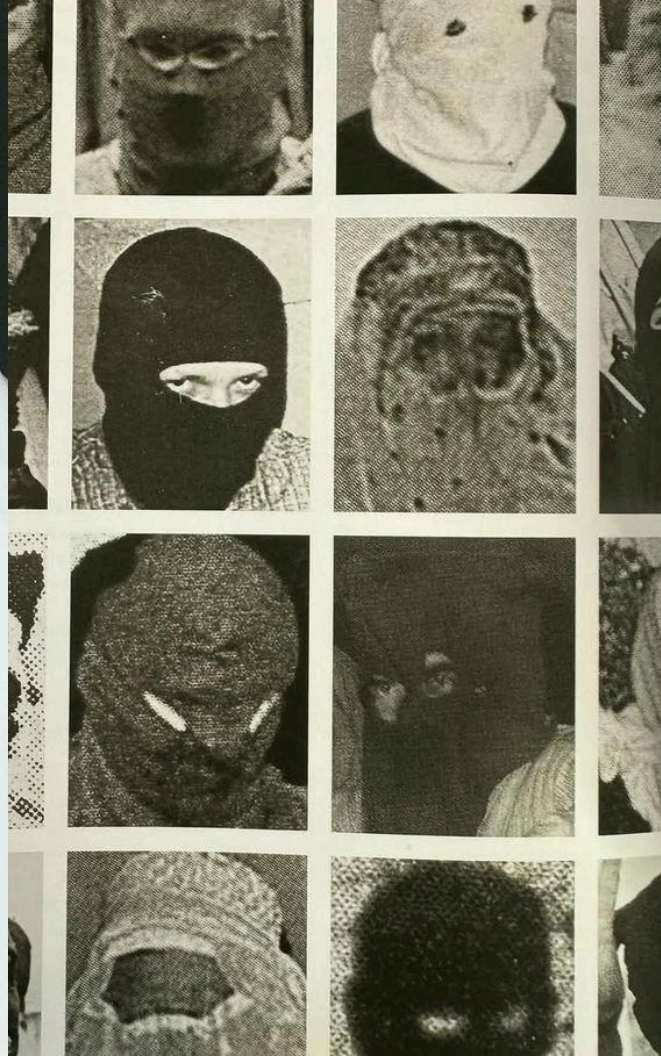


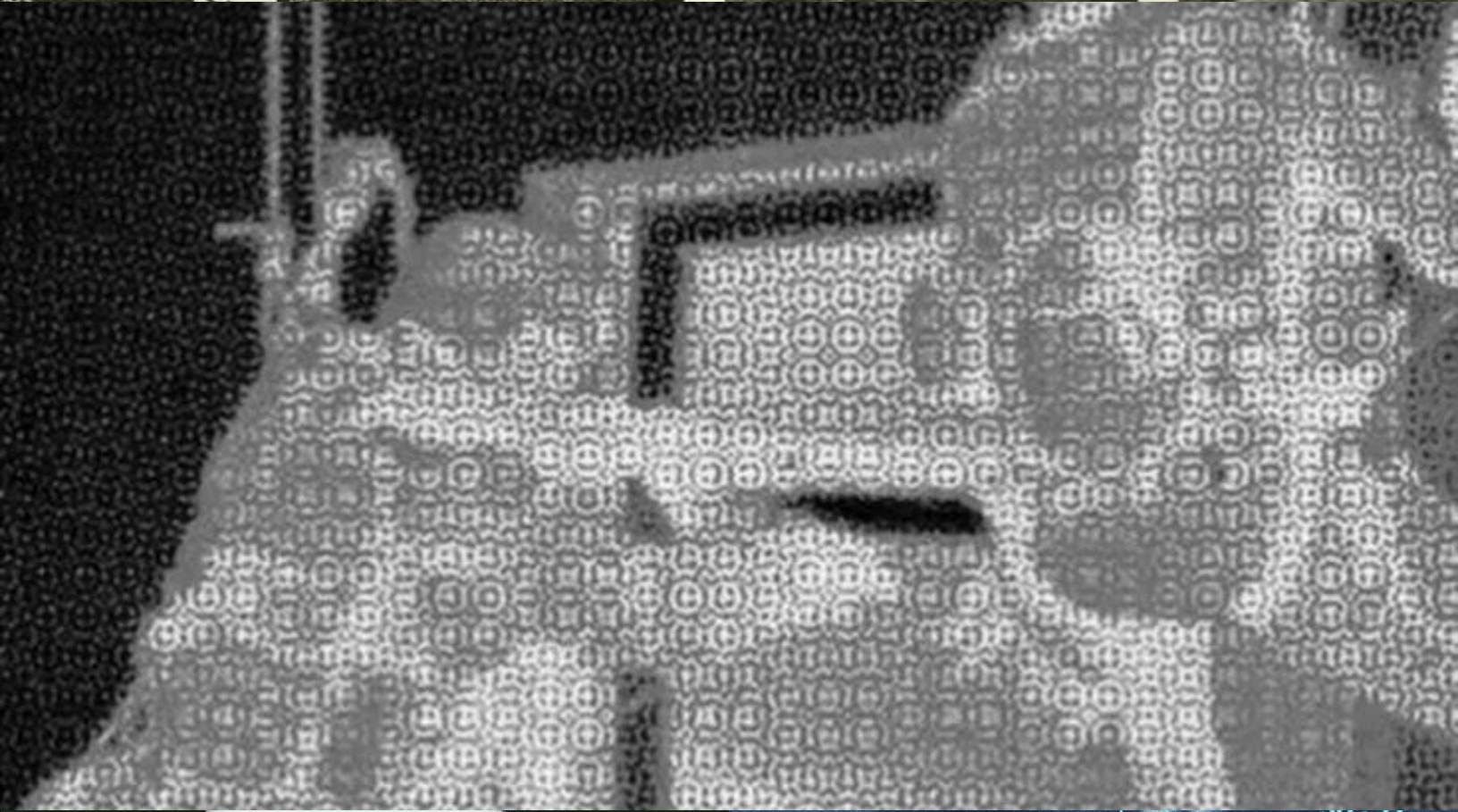
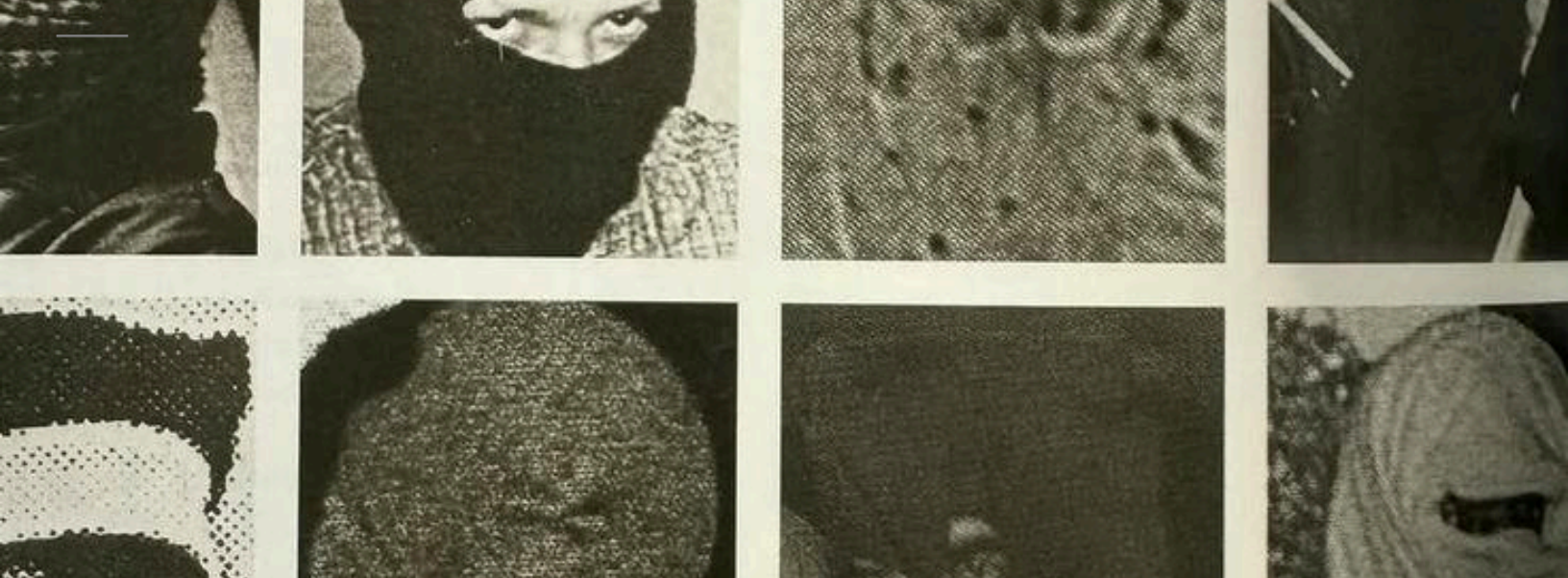
NO. 03 AUTUMN 2022

H-SPLIT



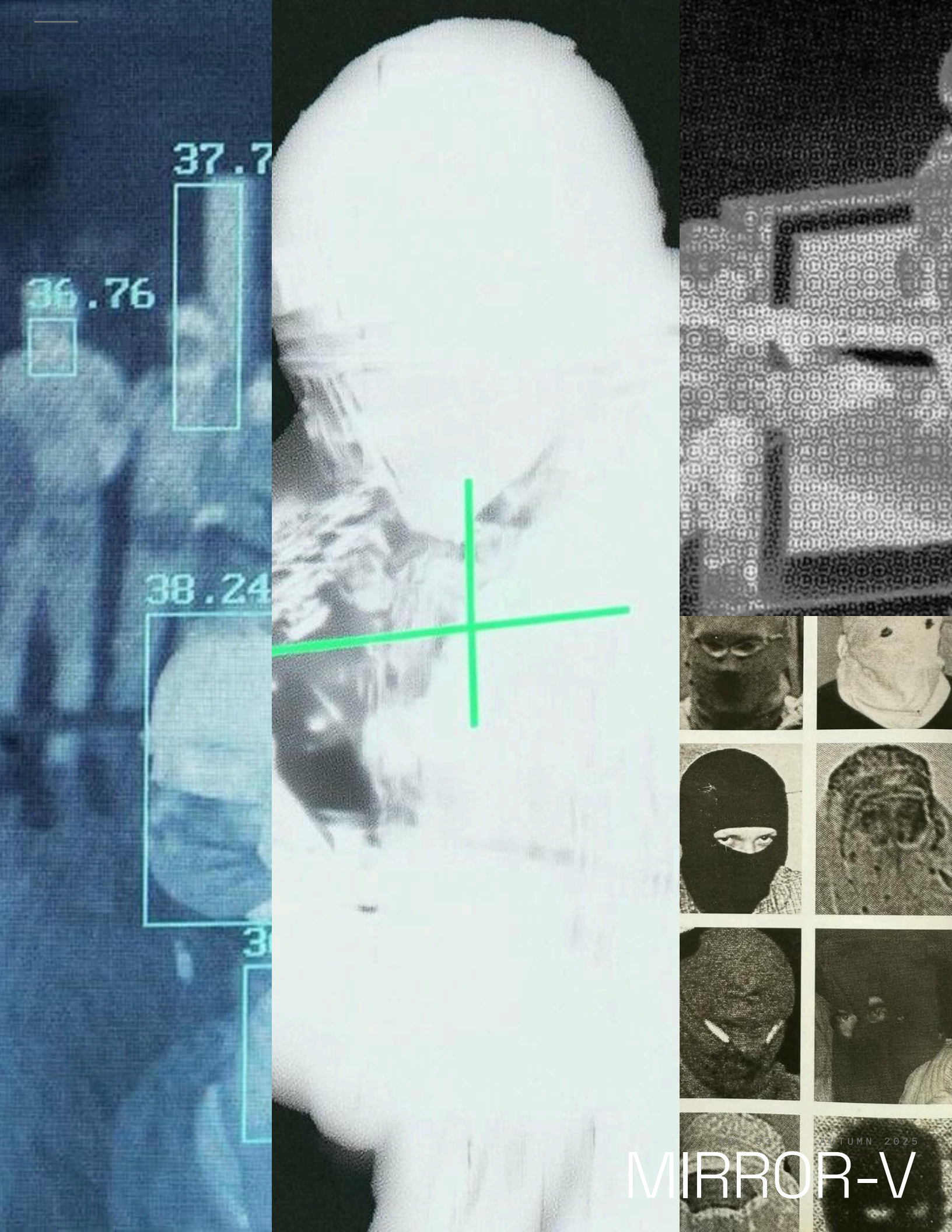






NO 03 · AUTUMN 2025

MIRROR-H



36.76

37.7

38.24

3

MIRROR-V

TUMN 2025

ON THE BUS PIECE (ISSUE 02) ____

You said the bus is slow because of choices, not physics. I've been thinking about this for three weeks. You're right and I hate it. — **J.W., Chicago**

CORRECTION ____

The Houston light rail does not go to the airport. We stated that it did. It does not. We regret this. — **the editors**

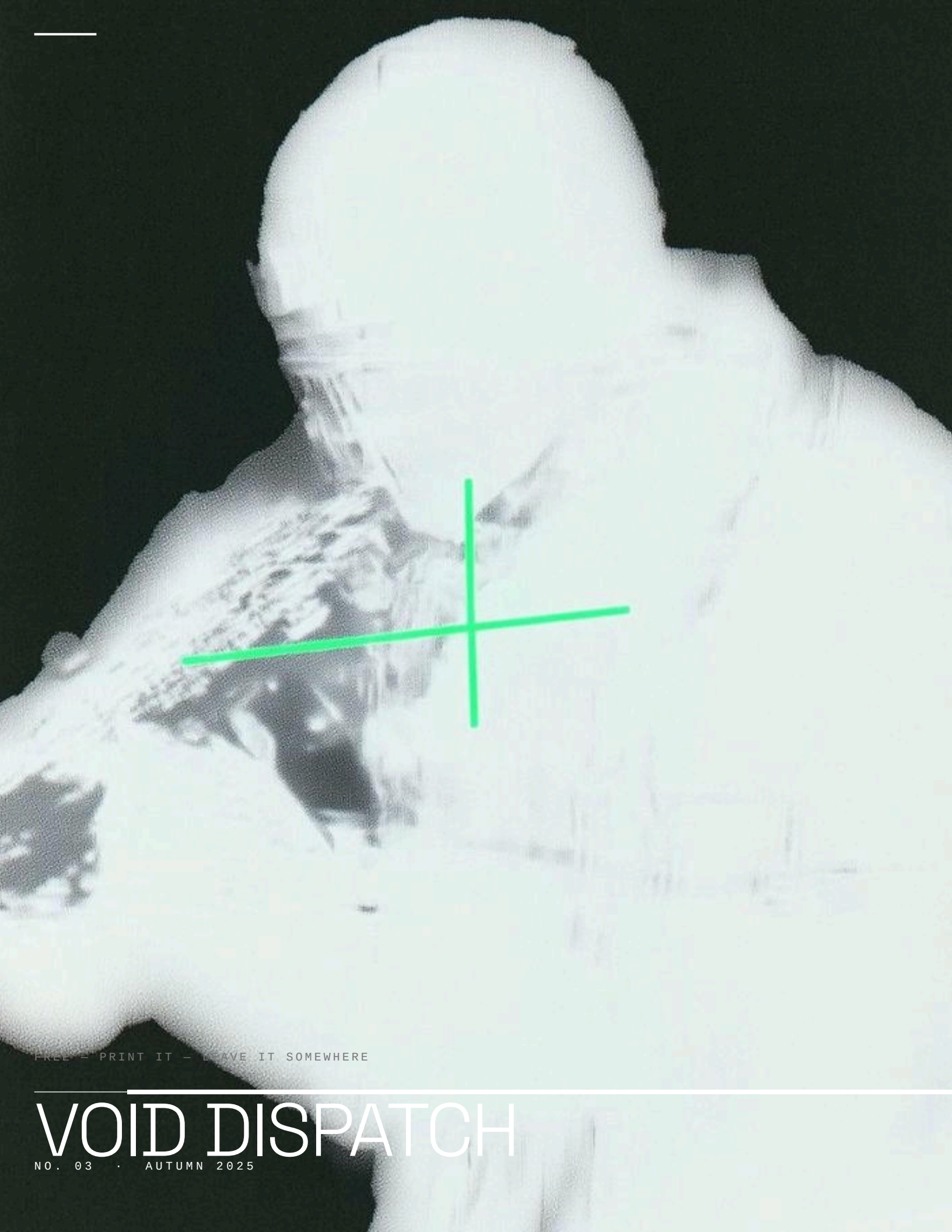
SUBMISSIONS ____

800 words or fewer. No pitches. Send it done. Plaintext. — **void-dispatch@proton.me**

Next issue: infrastructure that fights back. Submissions open. 800 words or fewer. No pitches. Send it done.

void-dispatch @ proton.me





FREE — PRINT IT — LEAVE IT SOMEWHERE

VOID DISPATCH

NO. 03 · AUTUMN 2025

